POISON IN PARADISE

Bhaktamara!

With this sombre Sanskrit word began the recitation of the Bhaktamara-stotra, a sacred hymn in honour of Adinath Jain, which the scholar and Jain priest Bhanu Chandra recited, the lilting cadences rippling through the magnificent Jain temple inside Lahore Fort. In front of Bhanu Chandra stood Akbar and Salim, head bowed, as they allowed these ancient verses to calm them, for a cold fear had settled in their hearts. Salim had just had a baby girl and the astrologers had quite disastrously decided that the constellation she was born under was harmful for Akbar. ‘Perform whatever is the purifying rite in the Jain philosophy!’ Akbar had ordered and Bhanu Chandra had suggested that they perform the Ashtottara-Sata-Snatra, a ceremony involving 108 baths to be given to the idol of Jina in the temple. After the completion of the hymn, the monk took some of the holy water from a gold pot and applied it to the Padshah’s eyes while his harem, Harkha Bai and his other Hindu wives, bowed before the pot and prayed for his health.

After his experience with Jain monks at Fatehpur Sikri, Akbar would continue to nurture the relationship between these priests and the Mughal court. Bhanu Chandra would stay at court well into the reign of Jahangir, and many other Jain scholars would continue to sporadically visit the Mughal court. These encounters, not mentioned in the Persianate texts, were meticulously recorded in Jain biographies.

While this incident shows the Padshah and his eldest son united in a common cause, both equally comfortable in seeking benediction from an unusual place, there is nonetheless a sense of a slow curdling of old, familiar affection. That danger to the Padshah’s life had been calculated as coming, even indirectly, from Salim’s family was unfortunate. It would have increased the prince’s sense of vulnerability and perhaps stoked Akbar’s paranoia.

Sometime in the year 1590, Akbar fell ill with a stomach upset and colic, which no remedy seemed able to alleviate. Badauni writes about this episode, during which ‘in this unconscious state (Akbar) uttered some